

Childishness or Consequences of Society

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Close Reading Essay - Romeo & Juliet

Though often classified merely as a tragic love story, William Shakespeare's *Romeo and Juliet* offers a nuanced exploration of societal dynamics through youthful impulsivity. The play has the infamous Romeo and Juliet from feuding families fall in love highlighting their defiance of their respective family expectations. Full of drama due to the hatred amongst the Montagues and the Capulets as well as influence by societal expectations, this culminates a tragic fate within a brief span of three days between the couple. The play's influence has spanned centuries and is popular today accumulating many reviews. Once such review came from Noah Berlantsy, who asserts that the play is "not childish, it's about childishness," a statement encapsulating Shakespeare's deeper critique of how societal expectations and familial authority exacerbate youthful recklessness. The tragedy of *Romeo and Juliet* displays acts of teenage imprudence, with Shakespeare assigning greater responsibility to entrenched family hostilities and constrictive social norms that transform youthful immaturity into violence, underscoring those social pressures, more than mere teen naiveté, shape the play's tragic outcome.

To illuminate the volatile nature of youthful impulsivity within society, Shakespeare crafts Mercutio's character as an embodiment of reckless arrogance shaped by familial prestige and societal rivalry. Mercutio's contemptuous dismissal of Romeo's pacifism is shown as he confronts Tybalt as he says, "O calm, dishonourable, vile submission! Alla stoccado carries it away" (3.1.72-73). Here, the fencing term "Alla stoccata" symbolizes Mercutio's readiness to engage physically, juxtaposed ironically against Romeo's desperate plea for peace. Mercutio's impulsiveness is not solely an individual failing but a reflection of broader societal expectations that idolize aggressive demonstrations of masculinity and honor. His inability to stay composed reveals a societal culture complicit in perpetuating dangerous norms of aggressive masculinity.

This lack of judgement led to Mercutio's death by Tybalt thus displaying the hatred between the families.

Transitioning deeper into this examination, Tybalt similarly embodies societal-infused impulsiveness through his vehement disdain for peace and relentless pursuit of violence. His assertion, "What, drawn, and talk of peace! I hate the word, As I hate hell, all Montagues, and thee" (1.1.68-69), employs paradoxical figurative language that equates peace with infernal weakness, dramatizing how societal conditioning fosters violent impulses. The irony in Tybalt's speech emerges because Juliet, his cousin, will soon fall in love with Romeo, a Montague, emphasizing how crucial peace is if the couple is to thrive. Tybalt's hatred towards the Montagues also creates a sense of situational irony by foreshadowing his violent end, reinforcing the destructive power of ingrained societal hostility. Tybalt's impulsive violence, thus, serves as a tragic perpetuation of hatred, underlining how deep-rooted societal rivalry fuels youth's destructive behavior.

Shakespeare further intensifies the exploration of youthful impulsivity through Juliet's symbolic characterization and biblical allusions. Juliet consistently embodies purity and innocence, symbolized vividly by the recurring motif of the color white. In the iconic balcony scene, Romeo employs apostrophe, elevating Juliet to an almost sanctified figure: "O, speak again, bright angel!" (2.2.26). The biblical imagery here symbolizes Juliet's perceived purity, sanctifying youthful love. It also simultaneously highlights its fragility in the face of societal pressures as she later reveals to Romeo "If they do see thee, they will murder thee" (2.2.70). Here, Juliet emphasizes that her family will kill him if they find him. Shakespeare thus illustrates how society corrupts youthful idealism, as external pressures forcibly strip Juliet's innocence, turning pure love into a pathway to ruin. Here love exceeds societal expectations, where the pair

would do anything for one another. However, this comes at a price that defies family boundaries which can ignite devastating consequences leading to a loss of purity and innocence.

Moreover, Shakespeare's poignant personification of death vividly conveys society's intimate yet destructive influence on youth. Capulet's anguished lamentation shows as he says, "Death is my son-in-law; Death is my heir" (4.5.44) when reacting to Juliet's fake death. In presenting death as an immediate part of the family, Shakespeare underscores how the hope of inheritance and a future lineage is replaced by a permanent and devastating finality. The repeated address to "Death" highlights the force's pervasive hold on these characters' fates, snuffing out any promise of renewal that Juliet's marriage might have represented. Although the audience knows she is not truly dead, the power of Capulet's grief, founded on this misunderstanding, propels the family closer to catastrophe. Death looms over both families and is personified to foreshadow the tragic ending that both families will have to live with due to their inability to foster peace. The figurative depiction of death signifies that the tragedy extends beyond mere individual misfortune, implicating society's role in perpetuating harmful cycles.

Yet, one could argue that the tragedy in *Romeo and Juliet* arises from intrinsic youthful immaturity rather than societal influence. Romeo's abrupt transition from Rosaline to Juliet indicates personal fickleness rather than societal culpability. His immediate infatuation, evidenced by him revealing "Did my heart love till now? Forswear it, sight!, For I ne'er saw true beauty till this night" (1.5.51-52) demonstrates how his rhetorical question, posed with exclamatory force, disrupts any sense of emotional continuity and reveals the volatility of adolescent affection. Romeo discards his prior devotion without hesitation, suggesting a sudden fixation on the thrill of new desire that overlooks wider family conflicts. Juliet's own quick acceptance of Romeo underscores the impression that both lovers surrender to passion with little

reflection, conveying impulsive behavior shaped more by raw emotion than by family or societal expectations. Such critics assert that their rapid romantic decisions and dramatic responses highlight natural youthful impulsiveness independent of familial or societal influence due to the timeline of the play. With the play's timeline limited to three days, Shakespeare symbolically accentuates how societal structures foster rash actions by intensifying pressures on youthful characters to conform rapidly to adult roles and responsibilities.

Shakespeare's *Romeo and Juliet* remains strikingly relevant today as a potent depiction of how societal and familial pressures can catalyze youthful impulsiveness toward tragedy. Contemporary societal conflicts, pressures from institutions, and generational misunderstandings continue to resonate profoundly in youth experiences today. Shakespeare's meticulous depiction of both older and new generation characters imparts enduring lessons, urging modern audiences to foster empathy and break destructive cycles rather than allow them to continue. Recognizing and addressing these societal shortcomings not only illuminate Shakespeare's enduring critique but also offers a profound framework for fostering empathy and guiding youthful potential constructively. To foster change, society must learn from Shakespeare message where prioritizing empathy, dialogue, and acceptance is vital to prevent youthful promise from turning into tragedy.

References

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